



Electronic Assistant: Not so great interface

allows you to do various tasks.

While adding contacts in Lotus Organizer 6.0, we found that it allows you to sort your contact list according to rules that could be set. Right-clicking on the contact list area and selecting Contacts Preferences allows you to customise the view of your contact list.

In RedBox Organizer 4.0, the address book can be accessed by clicking on the Address tab on the interface. The look of RedBox Organizer's address book is very colourful and attractive. Tabs have been made to categorise Business and Friends. There aren't too many fields to fill while entering data.

#### Mail features

If your PIM is well integrated with the e-mail client or provides you with mail features, it makes it that much more convenient for you to communicate not only with people on the network but also with individuals from all over the world.

**Microsoft Outlook** offered the best features, being primarily a mail client that is used widely. A whole lot of customisation options have been added to the software, such as various mail views. Mail can be sorted according to name or topic. It is well integrated with the browser and other

applications, so opening a Web site URL or other document received via mail is really simple.

Using RedBox Organizer is also really simple. It uses the default mail client from the operating system and automatically puts in the receiver's mail address, etc. Lotus Organizer also uses the default mail client when you choose to send a mail to someone.

Cute Organizer and Epoch Organizer both have basic mail client setup features that are easy to use. The only trouble is that you have to specify the password when you set up your mail account, unlike in Outlook, where you can choose to not do so during setup. That way, your inbox is secure because each time mail has to be sent or received, the password has to be given.

CyberContact is another PIM with a small, integrated mail client that allows



CyberContact: Integrates e-mail client

you to download and send mail.

#### Phone features

An in-built or well-integrated phone and fax dialler is the next thing to look out for in a PIM. But fax features are not as important nowadays since e-mail has become the preferred mode of communication, so

## PDA as a PIM

PDA's are becoming very popular nowadays, with companies like Palm and Handspring selling millions of these devices. Most of these PDAs use the versions of the Palm OS and allow users to write e-mail, take notes, store schedules, exchange visiting cards and set alarms. It's these PIM-like features that have made PDAs so popular with users who need to have access to this information when they are on the move. So if you are someone who needs a PIM at all times to stay organised, just get yourself a PDA.

only phone features are being discussed.

**Microsoft Outlook** scores again, because it is integrated with Microsoft's good old Windows phone dialler. It doesn't have too many features, but is good enough if you require simple dialling features for outgoing calls.

Most other PIMs, including RedBox Organizer and CyberContact, use the default Windows dialler software. Corel InfoCentral offers quite a few options such as international calling, etc for setting up the modem, which is done using the Windows wizard.

Day Timer Organizer 2000 is one of the best phone diallers around. It's a stand-alone phone dialler running completely on the PIM itself.

It offers the option to use calling cards in various countries. Incoming and outgoing calls can be recorded and logged with alerts and alarms. Office goers will certainly give this one a thumbs-up.

#### Export/Import features

Export and import features can be very useful if you have to move all your settings and contact lists from one software to another, using a specific file format such as CSV (Comma Separated Values). This is useful if you want to change your PIM or mail client or if you're moving to a machine that doesn't have your favourite PIM and you need your archive of contacts and other information.

**Microsoft Outlook** has the most comprehensive export and import features. You can export and import contact lists, mail accounts and mail into CSV or a whole list of formats available.

Lotus Organizer allows users to export data to a TXT file, and then import it

## Online PIMS

When you're on the move, you can't jolly well carry your PC around for a quick glance at your day's schedule or important telephone numbers. In this case, an online PIM is the best solution. Yahoo Calendar is one such online PIM. It can be accessed through the Yahoo Messenger client once you register for the service.

Online PIMs aren't very customisable and detailed, but they include all basic features like calendars, reminders and online diaries. Some additional features

are also usually available, such as news or horoscopes, which you don't get on your desktop PIM.

Online PIMs such as Web Event allow you to schedule work with a group of people over the Internet. Schedule Online has a wide range of accounts for all kinds of people, be it students or corporate executives. You can visit a site called FusionOne to sync contacts and notes between your mail client or PIM and the Internet.